

country's core have scripted many success stories. While the Supreme
These institutions provide the framework for a nation forever in transit.



LAL BHADUR SHASTRI NATIONAL ACADEMY OF ADMINISTRATION, MUSSOORIE **RIDING THE TIGER**

It's a battle akin to the one fought at the frontiers. Every year over three lakh youth fight it out for a chance to join the Indian Administrative Service (IAS), the so-called steel frame of India. But less than 100 make it to the IAS. Those who do, after running a gauntlet of years of preparation, can look forward to a stay in the Lal Bahadur Shastri National Academy of Administration (LBSNAA), a wi-fi campus set over 7,000 ft above sea level in Mussoorie. While the academy offers a three-month induction-level foundation course for all the civil servants who will run the nation's administrative services, police and railways, it is the chosen few who will breathe the air for a full two years. Not all of it in the campus though. Set up in 1951, LBSNAA forges unswerving national loyalty by sending its young probationers into the districts under a 52-week district-training session. On the campus, initiatives like the National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme, the Right to Information and the World Trade Organisation find space in the curriculum which aims at creating an army of professional generalists capable of handling a wide variety of tasks. Guest lecturers are drawn from all walks of life—from filmmakers and Cabinet ministers to social activists. The academy has signed MOUs with the governments of Sri Lanka and Bhutan to set up similar institutes there and is in talks to help set up an institute in Afghanistan. Elaborate lectures on public administration, management, law and economics prepare the young civil servants for the rough and tumble of the outside world—which they will eventually run. Good reason why Director Rudhra Gangadharan echoes Uncle Ben's advice to Spider-Man: "With great power comes great responsibility."

by Sandeep Unnithan

TAKING THE LEAD: (from left) Padamvir Singh, joint director, LBSNAA and Rudhra Gangadharan, director of the academy (second from left) with the faculty